

LEAKLISTEN · CALCULATION

LeakListen sizing calculations

Open Hardware Portfolio · amishchadha.com

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Document ID	LKL-CAL-001	Version	0.1
Status	Draft	Date	2026-09-25
Author	Amish Chadha	License	CERN-OHL-S-2.0
Project TRL	TRL 3 Proof of concept		
Repository	github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/leaklisten		
Source	docs/04-calcs/01-sizing.md @ 20fe831		

REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.1	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	First issue for TRL 3 (data and processing, airtime, energy and battery life, link budget through the cover, leak noise attenuation, sensor noise and resonances, detection distance, clock, magnet hold, chamber survival, size and mass, installation, false alarms, cost)

LeakListen sizing calculations

On paper, LeakListen meets seven of its fifteen requirements (four on paper, three by design), has four at risk, misses two and leaves two that cannot be checked until there is field data. The two misses are the ones the TRL 2 review feared. R7 (radio link) is not met: with a flat antenna under a cast-iron cover, and an assumed 20 dB cover loss, the link closes to about 0.53 km, not 1 km. R2 (plastic mains) is not met: a contact sensor on a valve hears the reference leak only a few metres along PVC or PE pipe. On iron mains the central estimate is about 185 m against the 100 m target, but the range spans about 93 to 370 m for plausible pipe losses, so R1 is at risk rather than met. The calculations changed four things in the TRL 2 concept: the seismic mass grows from about 11 g to about 53 g so that the sensor meets its noise target, the nightly summary shrinks from about 50 to 24 bytes so that it fits every LoRaWAN region, transmit power follows the regional limit (+14 dBm in EU868, not +20 dBm), and the clock is corrected weekly by the network. Every number in this note is printed by `docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`; the tag in brackets, for example [C1], is the line of that script's output that carries it.

Safety: These are first-principles estimates for a paper proof of concept. They do not replace confined space procedures, a lithium cell safety review or the utility's permission. Valve chambers can hold low-oxygen or toxic air; nothing in this note needs anyone to enter one. See LKL-PRC-001, Safety.

■ Scope and method

The note checks every requirement in LKL-REQ-001 v0.3 against the design in LKL-PRC-001 v0.3 and the parametric model `cad/src/model.py`. The script imports the model's `PARAMS`, derived dimensions and part solids, so the puck, seismic mass, logger tube, cable run and part volumes used here are the ones in the STEP files and in drawing LKL-DWG-001. It also reads `bom/bom.csv` and `budget_usd` in `project.yaml`, and writes the status table to `docs/04-calcs/results.csv`. Run it from the repo root with `python docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`.

The design case is a DN150 gate valve in a concrete chamber under a cast-iron cover, with the spindle cap 0.48 m below the street, a network pressure of 3 bar (44 psi) at night, and a LoRaWAN gateway 30 m up and 1 km away in an urban area.

■ Assumptions

Table 1. Main assumptions.

Area	Assumption	Basis
Electronics	Sleep 4 μ A; 12 mA while sampling and processing; 1 s of preamplifier settling per window; two 0.2 s receive windows at 5 mA per uplink	STM32WL-class figures; to confirm from the chosen module's datasheet
Radio	+14 dBm at 45 mA (EU868, as FieldNode); +20 dBm at 120 mA (US915); up to 3 transmissions a night	FieldNode FND-CAL-001 for EU868; the TRL 2 figure for US915
Cell	Li-SOCl ₂ C, 7.7 Ah, 70 % usable, 1 % a year self-discharge; carries up to 30 mA, the capacitor the rest	Typical bobbin cell; check against the chosen cell
Link	6 dB receiver noise figure; LoRa SNR limits -7.5 dB (SF7) to -20 dB (SF12); node antenna -3 dBi near the cover, 0.5 dB lead; gateway 2 dBi, 2 dB feeder; 10 dB fade margin; Okumura-Hata urban model at a 1 m mobile height	As FieldNode, with an urban rather than suburban path
Cover loss	10 dB composite cover; 20 dB cast-iron cover (central); 30 dB tight cover over a flooded chamber	Assumed, no verified source; the largest single uncertainty in R7
Pipe waves	Fluid-dominated axial wave below the ring frequency, wavenumber $k = k_f \sqrt{1 + 2Ba/(Eh(1 + i\eta))}$, model form after Gao et al. (2004); water B 2.2 GPa, 1,480 m/s	Gao, Brennan, Joseph, Muggleton and Hunaidi, J. Sound Vib. 277 (2004) 133 to 148
Pipes	Ductile iron 170 GPa, 6 mm wall; cast iron 100 GPa, 10 mm; PVC 3.3 GPa, 7.7 mm; PE100 1.2 GPa, 14.6 mm; loss factor including soil coupling 0.02 (iron), 0.065 (PVC), 0.10 (PE)	Handbook moduli; loss factors assumed
Leak source	5 L/min at 3 bar through a sharp orifice (Cd 0.6); acoustic efficiency 1e-6 to 1e-4 of the jet's mechanical power (central 1e-5), half into each direction, flat spectrum from 5 Hz to 2 kHz	Flat spectrum as in Gao et al. (2004); efficiency assumed
Sensing	Sensor acceleration = -10 dB coupling times the hoop acceleration of a ductile iron valve body (80 mm radius, 10 mm wall)	Assumed; the valve, not the pipe, is what the magnet touches
Background	Night vibration on the spindle cap 0.5 μ g/VHz above 100 Hz, rising as 1/f below	Assumed; site data will replace it
Sensor	Soft PZT, d33 300 pC/N; 20 mm ceramic, 0.23 mm, ϵ_r 1,800, $\tan \delta$ 0.02; JFET op-amp 5 nV/VHz with a 10 Hz 1/f corner; 1 nF feedback, 3 Hz high-pass	Typical buzzer ceramic and op-amp figures
Magnet	Rated pull 290 N (32 mm) on thick mild steel; 0.7 on cast or ductile iron; pull falls as $1/(1 + g/0.6 \text{ mm})^2$ with a coating gap g	Assumed gap law; to check against a supplier's curve
Clock	32.768 kHz crystal, ± 20 ppm at 25 $^{\circ}$ C, -0.034 ppm/ $^{\circ}$ C ²	Typical tuning-fork crystal

■ A. Nightly data, processing and payload (R5, R8, R14)

- **Data.** Twelve 20 s windows at 8 kS/s and 16 bits are 3.84 MB a night; 12 spectra of 64 bands, 1.54 kB, stay in RAM [A1]. Raw samples are processed as they arrive and never stored.
- **Resolution.** The 64 bands spaced evenly on a log scale from 5 Hz to 2 kHz are only 0.49 Hz wide at the bottom. A three-stage multirate scheme resolves every band: a 1,024-point FFT at the full rate for 80 Hz to 2 kHz, the same after decimating by 8 for 10 to 80 Hz, and a 512-point FFT after decimating by 32 for 5 to 10 Hz [A2].

- **Memory.** The signal path needs about 22 kB, and with a 32 kB allowance for the LoRaWAN stack the total is 54 kB of the STM32WLE5's 64 kB. The STM32WL has no floating-point unit, so processing is fixed point (q15) [A3].
- **Payload.** The TRL 2 summary of about 50 bytes does not fit US915's slowest rate (11 bytes at SF10) and takes 2.8 s at SF12. The summary is now 24 bytes: night minimum and 10th percentile levels, 16 band levels in 1 dB steps (the 64 bands merged four to one), the peak band, a steadiness index, battery, temperature, flags and a sequence number [A4]. The full 64-band spectrum stays on the device and can be requested later.

■ B. LoRaWAN airtime (R7, R14)

- **Time on air.** With 13 bytes of LoRaWAN overhead the 37-byte frame takes 82 ms at SF7, 267 ms at SF9, 494 ms at SF10 and 1.97 s at SF12 [B1].
- **Regional limits.** 24 bytes fits EU868 at every rate and US915 at SF9 or faster, within its 400 ms dwell limit (267 ms) [B2].
- **Fair use.** Three transmissions at SF12 use 5.9 s a day, 20 % of The Things Network's 30 s fair-use allowance, and each needs 197 s of silence under the 1 % duty cycle [B3]. R14 is met by design.

■ C. Energy and battery life (R6)

Table 2. Daily charge and battery life [C1].

Case	Sleep	Listening	Radio	Self-discharge	Total	Life on energy
EU868 SF7 +14 dBm	0.096	0.840	0.005	0.211	1.15 mAh	12.8 years
EU868 SF12 +14 dBm	0.096	0.840	0.076	0.211	1.22 mAh	12.1 years
US915 SF9 +20 dBm	0.096	0.840	0.028	0.211	1.18 mAh	12.6 years
TRL 2 case, 50 bytes at SF12, +20 dBm	0.096	0.840	0.281	0.211	1.43 mAh	10.3 years

- **R6 is met on paper.** Every case gives 10.3 years or more on 5.39 Ah usable; life is still taken as 10 years, limited by cell and seal ageing. Listening, not radio, dominates: 59 % of the worst day [C2]. The TRL 2 figure of about 1.15 mAh a day stands for the EU868 case.
- **Pulse capacitor.** A bobbin cell carrying 30 mA leaves 0.06 F of capacitance to cover an EU868 SF12 burst and 0.05 F for US915 SF9, over a 0.5 V droop; a +20 dBm burst as long as SF12 would need 0.36 F [C3]. The main board specifies a hybrid layer capacitor of 0.1 F or more.

■ D. Radio link from under the cover (R7)

Table 3. Link margin at 1 km after the 10 dB fade margin, and the range at zero margin [D1], [D2].

Radio	Link budget	Composite cover (10 dB)	Iron cover (20 dB)	Tight iron cover, flooded (30 dB)
EU868 SF12, +14 dBm	147.5 dB	+0.3 dB; 1.02 km	-9.7 dB; 0.53 km	-19.7 dB; 0.28 km
US915 SF9, +20 dBm	146.0 dB	-1.8 dB; 0.89 km	-11.8 dB; 0.46 km	-21.8 dB; 0.24 km
EU868 SF7, +14 dBm	135.0 dB	-12.2 dB; 0.45 km	-22.2 dB; 0.23 km	-32.2 dB; 0.12 km

Bold values miss 1 km. The urban Hata path loss at 1 km is 127.3 dB at 868 MHz and 127.9 dB at 915 MHz.

- **R7 is not met.** Under the central iron cover the link reaches about 0.5 km at the slowest rate. To close 1 km the cover may cost no more than 10.3 dB (EU868 SF12) or 8.2 dB (US915 SF9) [D3], which only a composite cover or a through-cover antenna is likely to give.
- **Transmit power.** EU868 limits the uplink to 14 dBm ERP (16.15 dBm EIRP), so the TRL 2 assumption of +20 dBm is not permitted there [D4]; the design now uses +14 dBm in EU868, as FieldNode does, and up to +20 dBm in US915.
- **Options.** The decision on a through-cover antenna, a composite cover or a gateway within about 0.5 km of each district is proposed in docs/REVIEW.md, awaiting Amish. Cover loss is assumed, not measured; it must be measured before any option is chosen.

■ E. Leak noise attenuation along the pipe (R1, R2)

- **Wave speed.** The fluid-dominated wave travels at about 1,270 m/s in the iron mains and 394 m/s (PVC) and 338 m/s (PE) in the plastic ones, because a compliant wall slows it [E1].
- **Attenuation.** On ductile iron it is 0.011 dB/m at 100 Hz and 0.11 dB/m at 1 kHz; on PVC 0.42 dB/m at 100 Hz and 4.2 dB/m at 1 kHz; on PE nearly twice the PVC figure [E1]. Over 100 m of iron, a 200 Hz tone loses 2.2 dB; over 30 m of PVC it loses 25.1 dB and a 50 Hz tone 6.3 dB [E2]. This agrees in kind with the low-frequency, narrow-band leak signals on plastic pipes that Gao et al. (2004) and Hunaidi and Chu (1999, cited in LKL-PRB-001) describe.

■ F. Sensor: sensitivity, self-noise and resonances (R3, R4)

- **Sensitivity.** In compression, a piezo disc's charge output is d33 times the seismic mass. The TRL 2 mass of about 11 g gives 32 pC/g; the TRL 3 mass, a brass cylinder 20 mm x 20 mm of about 53 g, gives 157 pC/g. The disc has 21.8 nF; the charge amplifier uses 1 nF and 53 MΩ [F1].
- **Self-noise.** Op-amp voltage noise across the disc capacitance, the feedback resistor's current noise and the disc's dielectric loss give 1.03 µg/√Hz at 100 Hz, 0.83 at 300 Hz and 0.76 at 1 kHz, and 2.95 µg/√Hz at 10 Hz. With the TRL 2 mass the figures were five times higher [F2]. The worst value from 100 Hz to 1 kHz is 1.03 µg/√Hz against the 1 µg/√Hz target [F3], so **R4 is at risk**, 3 % over the target on assumed ceramic and op-amp data. The ADC's contribution is negligible after the 40 dB stage [F4].
- **Seismic resonance.** In compression the disc and mass resonate far above the band, near 200 kHz [F5]. A disc used as a bender, the other way to raise sensitivity, would resonate inside the band.
- **Mounted resonance.** The puck and magnet weigh about 210 g. On a contact stiffness of 5 to 20 MN/m, typical of a magnet on a painted cap but assumed, they resonate at 776 to 1,553 Hz and stay within 3 dB only up to 420 to 840 Hz [F6]. A fixed correction cannot remove a resonance that changes from site to site, so **R3 is at risk** above about 400 Hz. This matters for R1: the band that sets the detection distance on iron is the 800 Hz third octave (section G), at the edge of the flat range. Near the resonance the mount amplifies the leak and the background alike, so the level is site-dependent rather than lost; the nightly trend compares a logger with itself, which tolerates this better than an absolute threshold would.

■ G. Detection distance (R1, R2)

The reference leak (5 L/min at 3 bar) is a 24.5 m/s jet through a 2.7 mm orifice, 25 W of mechanical power at a Mach number of 0.017 [G1]. The script spreads a fraction of that power over the pipe as a flat spectrum, turns the in-pipe pressure into valve acceleration and, in each third-octave band, finds the distance at which the attenuated leak level falls to the combined background and sensor noise. At that distance the band level rises by 3 dB, enough for the nightly minimum to show it.

Table 4. Detection distance for the reference leak [G2].

Pipe	Efficiency 1e-6	Efficiency 1e-5 (central)	Efficiency 1e-4	Target
Ductile iron DN150	105 m	185 m	325 m	100 m (R1)
Cast iron DN150	99 m	175 m	308 m	100 m (R1)
PVC DN150	2 m	4 m	7 m	30 m (R2)
PE100 DN150 SDR11	1 m	2 m	4 m	30 m (R2)

- **Limiting band.** The detection distance is set by the 800 Hz third octave on iron and the 1 kHz band on plastic [G2]. Leak pressure turns into valve acceleration in proportion to the square of frequency, so the higher bands win until pipe attenuation takes over.
- **R1 is at risk.** The central estimate on ductile iron is 185 m, but halving or doubling the pipe loss factor moves it to 370 m or 93 m [G3], and the source efficiency spans a factor of 100. Only field recordings of known leaks can pin these down.
- **R2 is not met.** A contact sensor on a valve hears only a few metres along a plastic main in this model; halving the pipe loss factor gives 8 m [G3]. The model is pessimistic at low frequency, because a stiff metal valve body converts pressure into very little acceleration there, and practice with hydrophones on plastic mains reaches further. That is the case for the hydrophone variant kept open in decision D3; the choice of scope for plastic networks is proposed in `docs/REVIEW.md`.

■ H. Clock (R5)

- **Free running.** A ± 20 ppm crystal in a chamber at 5 to 20 °C drifts by 54 to 87 s in 30 days [H1], which misses the 1 min a month in R5.
- **Corrected.** A weekly network time request (LoRaWAN 1.0.3 DeviceTimeReq, answered by any compliant network server) holds the error to 20 s at worst [H2]. **R5 is met on paper** with that correction, which is now part of the design.

■ I. Magnet hold (R9)

Table 5. Pull on a cast or ductile iron spindle cap [I1].

Magnet	0.1 mm gap (bare)	0.3 mm (paint)	0.5 mm (paint and rust)	1.0 mm (heavy coating)
32 mm pot, 290 N rated (fitted)	149 N	90 N	60 N	29 N
42 mm pot, about 600 N rated (option)	309 N	187 N	125 N	59 N

- **R9 is at risk.** The fitted magnet meets 100 N only on a bare or lightly coated cap; a 42 mm magnet (it fits the 50 mm cap) meets it up to a 0.5 mm coating. The magnet itself carries only about 2.3 N of static load, since the puck sits on top of the cap [I2]; the 100 N target covers a snagged cable or a knock. Non-ferrous caps still need an adapter. The larger magnet is proposed in docs/REVIEW.md .

■ J. Chamber survival (R11)

- **Submersion.** 1 m of water puts 9.8 kPa on the O-rings and the M12 socket [J1], well within the rating of static O-ring seals and IP68 connectors.
- **Flooding.** The logger body weighs about 462 g and displaces 748 g of water, so in a flooded chamber it floats up against the lanyard with 2.8 N [J2]. The lanyard and the hanger must carry that; they do by a wide margin.
- **Condensation.** The free air in the tube holds about 5 mg of water at saturation; a 10 g silica gel pack holds about 2,000 mg [J3]. Long-term vapour ingress through the seals cannot be estimated on paper. **R11 is met by design;** a submersion test is TRL 4 work and on hold.

■ K. Size, mass and installation (R10, R12)

- **Size and mass.** The logger is 63 mm in diameter and 240 mm long, 267 mm with its socket and gland. By part volume and density the whole set weighs 0.93 kg: the PVC housing 325 g, the cable 140 g, the cell 90 g and the puck, magnet and mass about 200 g [K1]. **R12 is met on paper**, though the TRL 2 estimate of 0.7 kg was light; the solid PVC end plugs in the massing model are heavier than moulded ones would be.
- **Reach.** The cable plug sits 0.39 m below the street, so the 2 m cable with 0.3 m of slack reaches a spindle cap 2.09 m down, covering chambers up to the 1.5 m of R10 [K2].
- **Time.** The task estimate is 10 min: 3 min for cones and cover, 2 min to lower the puck on a pole, 1 min to hang the logger, 2 min to check the network join and 2 min to close up [K3]. It sits at the R10 limit and has not been shown with a crew, so **R10 is not verifiable at TRL 3**.

■ L. False alarms (R13)

Random night-to-night scatter in the minimum level does not cause false alarms: with a 2 dB scatter and a flag at +6 dB for three nights, the rate is about 1e-6 per 20 loggers a month, and 7e-3 even at 3 dB scatter [L1]. Real false alarms come from persistent changes: a pump schedule, a pressure reducing valve that starts to hunt, a customer's night irrigation. Their rate is a property of the network, so **R13 is not verifiable at TRL 3**.

■ M. Cost (R15)

Eleven BOM lines, every one priced, total \$109.00 against the \$130 budget, a margin of \$21.00 [M1]. The larger seismic mass adds \$1. **R15 is met on paper.** The proposed 42 mm magnet would add about \$4 (\$113).

■ N. Requirement status

Table 6. Requirement status from this note [N]. Not met first, then at risk.

ID	Requirement	Value	Target	Status
R2	Hear a leak on plastic mains	4 m on PVC at central efficiency (2 to 7 m); 2 m on PE	30 m	Not met
R7	Radio link	-9.7 dB at 1 km under an iron cover (EU868 SF12); range 0.53 km	90 % delivery at 1 km	Not met
R1	Hear a leak on metallic mains	185 m on ductile iron at central efficiency (93 to 370 m)	100 m	At risk
R3	Sensor bandwidth	Mounted resonance 776 to 1,553 Hz; flat to 420 to 840 Hz	5 Hz to 2 kHz, ± 3 dB after correction	At risk
R4	Sensor self-noise	1.03 $\mu\text{g}/\text{VHz}$ worst from 100 Hz to 1 kHz	1 $\mu\text{g}/\text{VHz}$	At risk
R9	Attachment	90 N at a 0.3 mm coating (149 N bare)	100 N	At risk
R10	Install from the surface	10 min task estimate; reach to 2.09 m	10 min, 1.5 m, no entry	Not verifiable at TRL 3
R13	Leak flag quality	Random scatter negligible; site events unknown	1 per 20 loggers per month	Not verifiable at TRL 3
R5	Night listening	20 s worst with weekly time correction	12 windows, under 1 min a month	Met on paper
R6	Battery life	10.3 years or more on energy	5 years	Met on paper
R12	Size and mass	63 x 267 mm, 0.93 kg	70 x 300 mm, 1.0 kg	Met on paper
R15	Cost	\$109.00	\$130	Met on paper
R8	Data and privacy	Processed as sampled, deleted on device	Only levels and spectra leave	Met by design
R11	Survive the chamber	IP68 parts; floats on its lanyard when flooded	IP68, -20 to +50 °C	Met by design
R14	Open and interoperable	24-byte LoRaWAN 1.0.3 uplink, documented	Standard LoRaWAN	Met by design

■ O. TRL 2 figures checked

Table 7. TRL 2 figures against this note.

TRL 2 figure	This note	Outcome
3.84 MB sampled a night	3.84 MB [A1]	Stands
About 50 bytes sent a night	24 bytes [A4]	Changed; the precis is updated
About 1.15 mAh a day	1.15 to 1.22 mAh [C1]	Stands
About 12.8 years on energy, about 10 years life	10.3 to 12.8 years [C1]	Stands
Radio at 20 dBm, 120 mA	+14 dBm in EU868 [D4]	Changed
Magnet hold about 95 N, marginal	90 N at 0.3 mm, 60 N at 0.5 mm [I1]	Stands; at risk
63 x 240 mm, about 0.7 kg	63 x 240 mm (267 mm overall), 0.93 kg [K1]	Mass changed; the precis is updated
About \$108 in parts	\$109.00 [M1]	Changed by \$1